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The Apocalypse: Discarding Enlightenment's Veil /

The most dangerous form of deception is inception. The type you are not even aware of and take for granted so deeply that it forms the very lens in which you see the entire world. An idea planted so deeply in everything you read and think about that it becomes like a mind parasite that consumes the energy of every thought and formation of intuition. Worse yet, is the denial of any possible mediation as a priori -- that is, the complete disembodiment of being, at multiple levels.

I suppose it's important that I start with a concrete example, something that is taken for granted so deeply by the majority of thinkers that it may appear insane to even question such an unassailable statement:

"I think, therefore I am." (Cogito, ergo sum) - Descartes

This statement is easy to digest for most people, but as I hope to make you see by the end of this thread, flips reality on its head. Reading this statement as a living person it contains true statements on both sides.

You're surely "thinking" while reading this statement.
You surely "are" while your vision (or hearing/feeling if blind) traces over each word.

True, therefore true?...

So it almost appears, as one reads it, a tautology. That isn't quite what Rene Descartes meant, he was going for something more abstract -- that you think at all means you are, independent of anything else. In fact, in rejection of everything possible, the ultimate atomised individuality.

At a higher level, what this statement said is the following: Epistemology conditionally proves ontology. That is: the metaphysical is now conditional to its rational formulation. This is a sharp departure from Platonic forms, which exist in a transcendental realm independent of so-called rational thought. In a sense, Descartes in his "Meditations" captured everything in reality (including God, lol) and trapped them within his oddly shaped head.

You see, the "cogito" statement itself is far bolder and less personal to the reader than it appears to the reader. The "I" is very much Descartes or anyone who chooses to deploy his theory. This formed what is termed Cartesian dualism: a "non-physical" indivisible mind ("res cogitans") and a completely mechanical physical body ("res extensa"). The former's existence, in the observer's mind, proves the existence of the latter, but this is later extended to everything.

It is this theory we will initially dissect, destroy and later, invert entirely, arriving at a result that will surely surprise most people. One thing I want to point out is that if you are like me, you've probably never really even questioned this dual of the mind and body -- it has likely been drilled into you since birth. Perhaps the more religious of you refer to this mind as a soul? Did you know that there was an alternative that Descartes successfully killed for most people? Not only that, this alternative philosophy was so old and established that it is undateable. Older than Platonic forms. Yet, today, most have never heard of it despite it once reigning supreme. We'll return to this later in the thread, and with all we have learnt about reality with our recent findings and instruments, I believe it will form a true revelation. An apocalypse, in the proper revealing sense of the world rather than the popular sense of physical destruction.

Now returning to the question of the so-called enlightenment, which I believe is the reverse of said apocalypse, Descartes, formed the philosophical pillar of the enlightenment. Almost every single modern philosopher you have heard of since him, has taken his dualism for granted, even as they defeated every other part of its formulation. This includes figures like:

Spinoza (even adopting the framework from a monist perspective), Leibniz, Locke, Hume, Kant, Hegel, Schopenhauer, Marx. Any philosophy, ethics or science built on the other's formulations will be irreparably tainted by the flaws that we will be attacking in this thread. All of today's dead society is built upon this idea, even your online social interactions!

Interestingly, Nietzsche rejected the framework altogether and even predicted that someone would write this very thread you are reading, and yet still came to the same awful wrong conclusion his own way. Actually, the only* person to get things right was David Bohm, because he removed the veil himself in his book "Wholeness and the Implicate Order" (1980) -- but didn't synthesise the conclusion because he was a very gentle, cautious and serious man who didn't get to live to see the vindication of his theories. Unlike Descartes, Bohm was not only a philosopher but also a physicist. A man who wielded both ontology and epistemology.

For reasons related to this, we are going to be forced to examine not only Descartes in this thread, but also the science pillar of the enlightenment. This other pillar was formed by Englishman Francis Bacon. Bacon worked in almost the opposite direction as Descartes but towards the same goal.

For Bacon, reality is as follows: "It has been tested empirically, so I can build on it". Seems reasonable, right? In fact, you might say, it's even harder to argue against this than Descartes! We will quickly see how flawed empirical evaluation is, but there is one sleight of the hand you could miss in adopting both of these. Bacon restricts the scientist from thinking about philosophy, and Descartes restricts the philosopher from using their senses thus conducting science. A double severance at either end. Only through their institutions can knowledge be gained. This was the beginning of compartmentalisation.

Meanwhile, both of them rejected everything that came before them -- Bacon going as far as using Abrahamist/Yahwehist symbolism, of smashing four different kinds of "idols". Descartes invoking a demiurge-like demon which steals his senses and ability to measure.

When taken both together, their "enlightenment" leaves us in a collective amnesia and creates a dual: a scientist and a philosopher, one restricted to measurements and , and another trapped in his thoughts forever. Neither of whom have any connections to the "idols" of the past, smashed to bits by these two curious men.

Descartes promised a utopia, as did Bacon in "New Atlantis", should their formula be followed. Bacon proposed "torturing" nature until it spilled the beans about the truth through empiricism. Descartes on the other hand, declared primacy of human consciousness, denying it to animals and instead deeming them mere machines or automata. This essentially severed our connection to nature, beyond just the past. Today, as humans are deemed "animals" too, we find ourselves under the same kind of harmful assertion.

I will not stop at these two though, I will take you all the way to today in 2025. All the way to quantum mechanics, LLMs, discoveries about space, time, nature and beyond. The "enlightenment" was damaging, in fact, it gave birth to disastrous revolutions, dehumanisation, savage wars, absolute nihilism, destruction of faith for many and desolation in the form of the loneliness epidemic. You will quickly come to understand that these two men, or more accurately, those behind these two men, intended this exact outcome.

But that's not what this thread is about. This thread is all about us achieving what they never could: the unveiling of reality. This cannot be done by myself alone! In fact, that's the entire point of this thread, as you will see, the unveiling is something that has to be done by the entire world, but it is precisely this moment that this unveiling is not only possible but inevitable. The unveiling is communication about this, about destroying each boundary and veil they have put up for us. We finally have the tools and knowledge to do it.

If I do not write this thread, someone else shortly will! The hard work has already been done, arguably, thousands of years ago, by ancient philosophers, by Jesus Christ, by early Christians, by Bohm and many experimentalists, technologists today. For the latter though, this is not the singularity that the transhumanists wanted. 😂 Instead, this will be, a restorative one that will most definitely awaken everyone from their collective amnesia once a critical threshold is crossed! The anti-thesis is our current dying society, there will be no synthesis in the Hegelian fashion, we will absolutely smash what they built and transcend it.

Are you ready oomfies? If so sit back, relax, and enjoy this thread about philosophy, science and teleology -- purpose.

* I will note that Heidegger, Whitehead and Merleau-Ponty rejected the Cartesian framework and worked beyond it. They came very very close to connecting epistemology (the how), ontology (the what) and teleology (the why) together, but missed some key results due to their lifetime window. If they were alive today, they would have been writing this thread instead of your Baka! May they rest in peace. ❤️

Let us first immerse ourselves in Renaissance Europe to fully appreciate the scientific, philosophical, religious and ultimately political context which resulted in the veil over our eyes today.

We begin in 1440, when the German inventor Johannes Gutenberg invented printing press. This device allowed new and old ideas could be propagated at great speed, enabling advancements in technology, literacy and even artistic pursuits. It was the social media of the time, but like every tool that could do good, it could also cause great harm!

In the early 1500s, Martin Luther used the printing press to succeed where his predecessors failed, launching the protestant reformation and sinking Europe into chaos. The catholic church's normal methods of dealing with such "heretics" did not work, and in the aftermath the church became far more defensive and inflexible towards any challenge to its authority.

In the meantime, the literacy rates across Europe skyrocketed, creating the perfect conditions for advancements in technology -- and the need for reading glasses. This meant lens making techniques would have to advance rapidly, creating a demand for optics books,

which the printing press readily provided. These two technologies had a synergistic economy with each feeding demand for the other. One particular town in the Netherlands, Middelburg in the Zeeland province, became the centre of excellence for lens making. In 1608, this resulted in the invention of the telescope, which would finally put some cosmic assertions under the test.

Two years later, Galileo would use this telescope to make a discovery that would change the course of history despite it being a very minor one in retrospect. To understand why, we have to take a little step back from technology and science, then step into the world of philosophy and theology.

The catholic church's authority was coming under challenge, and its teleology through papacy undermined. The church, at the time, favoured the Aquinas scholasticism which was a more complex and purposeful method than the Hegelian dialectic most people today would be familiar with.

At the time, Europe had largely adopted an Aristotelian metaphysical view, after much of his work was transmitted to the continent via the Moors of Spain. Aquinas developed the scholastic method by which opposing viewpoints can be reconciled, usually to reinforce the Catholic church's scriptural viewpoints, without contradicting the trends of the time. This became exceedingly difficult as more observations of the cosmos and nature became known. Yet, the church still preferred this gradual approach which protected teleology while ontology and epistemology flourished -- fulfilling the church's guardianship role.

One particularly troublesome conflict was the 3rd century AD Ptolemaic model of our Solar system, inspired by Aristotle. In this Ptolemaic model, all the planets, stars and our current sun (Sol) orbited the Earth, with a twist! They all went through epicycles along their orbit, compensating for the motion of the Earth around the sun.

It only takes a moment of consideration to find an issue with this model: Due to Mercury and Venus's closer proximity to the sun, their epicycles would have to overlap each other's and the moon's. This means that we should see "phase cycles" that the Ptolemaic model could not account for and these were only observable by the telescope! The Ptolemaic model which established the Earth as the centre of the universe with everything else orbiting, couldn't be right. Well before the telescope's invention, Copernicus had already worked this out by doing away with the epicycles altogether:

This was not accepted however, and without any contradictory observations, people held on to existing views. Why would the church even care about this? As the Catholic church's (and almost every other mainstream sect) maintains that all its canon scripture was divinely inspired, these particular verses would create an obvious contradiction:

Psalm 104:5 - "He set the earth on its foundations; it can never be moved."
Psalm 93:1 - "The world is firmly established; it cannot be moved."
Psalm 96:10 - "Say among the nations, 'The Lord reigns.' The world is firmly established, it cannot be moved."
1 Chronicles 16:30: "Tremble before him, all the earth! The world is firmly established; it cannot be moved."

In 1610 Galileo made the inevitable observation of multiple phases of Venus, and quietly shared his empirical work in 1611. Jesuit astronomers took notice, and readily replicated the result. Cardinal Robert Bellarmine requested a formal opinion from the Collegio Romano mathematicians. They came up with the perfect solution that accommodated the church's requirements: Adopting the Tychonian model, nearly identical to an even older 4th century BC model by Heraclides*, where the Sun, Moon and stars orbit the Earth, and the planets orbit the Sun:

Galileo published his Venus observations in 1611, but did not advocate for any particular view. He was someone who even taught the geocentric model, and it took him until 1613 to accept his own observations and begin to advocate for the heliocentric model. He wrote a letter to the Italian mathematician Benedetto Castelli where he made a very bold statement, that his empirical results took primacy over scripture -- and that the latter should only be a matter of faith.

Just three years later, the church declared the heliocentric model, and Copernicus, heretical. Galileo was formally warned by the church, but continued to advocate for it in private and conduct research in this direction. In 1632, he published a work "Dialogue Concerning the Two Chief World Systems" which he set up as a scholastic argument, advocating for the geocentric model.

In the book, dialogue took place between three fictional characters:

Salviati (representing Galileo)
Simplicio (the word resembling sempliciotto which means 'simpleton')
And an observer, Sagredo.

In the book, Salviati made amazing arguments, while Simplicio struggled. More corrosively, the Pope (Urban VIII), had made almost identical arguments to this character. To maintain plausible deniability, Sagredo would declare no winner at the end of the book.

The Pope, who was so far quite lenient towards Galileo, felt rightfully betrayed by this mockery and straw-manning.

Just six month later, Pope Urban VIII placed the book on a ban list, ordering a halt to its distribution. The printing presses complied, and even protestants did not like Galileo's actions. He was placed under house arrest shortly afterwards, and conducted some research on inertia which we will revisit later in the thread.

Galileo was what you would call a scientist today, concerned with empirical observations more so than scriptural interpretation. He, like any nerd today, failed to read the room and paid the price for it. He didn't appreciate the complicated political, theological and societal considerations that the church had to balance. So he got cancelled for his trouble.

A far more politically adept albeit destructively secretive observer, Rene Descartes, correctly read the room. He was writing a book (Le Monde) advocating heliocentrism, but immediately ceased work on it in light of Galileo's arrest. As this represented many years of

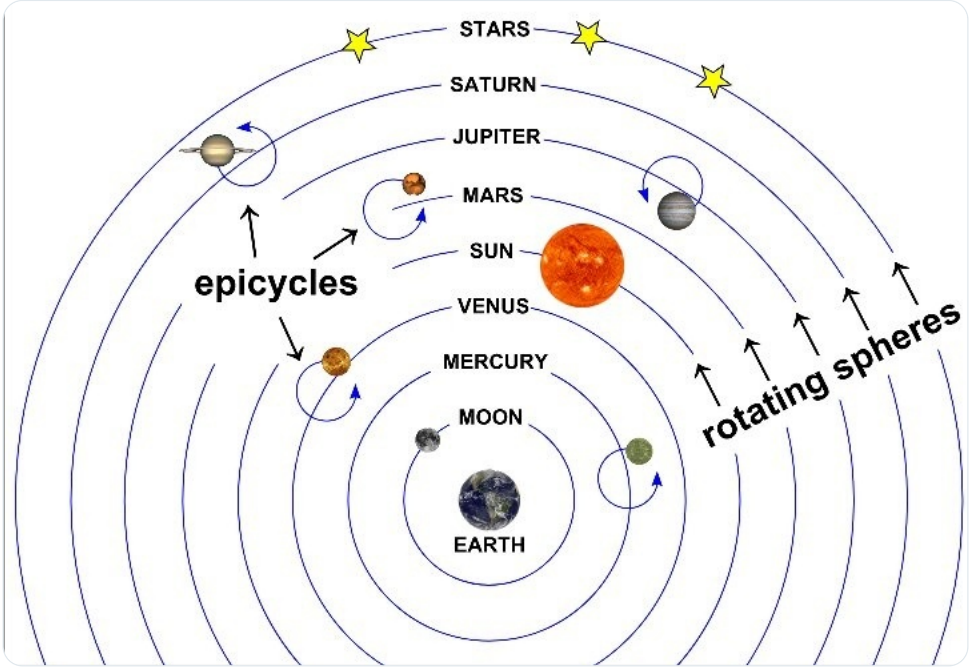
his work, this surely left a very bitter taste in his mouth. After Galileo's arrest, Descartes saw the scholastic method along with theology in general, as a barrier to what he thought of as progress. A barrier that needed to be torn down along with the history and perhaps even the deity behind him.

Descartes was Jesuit educated, and somewhat politically adept, but extremely hard to collaborate with and not a particularly good mathematician. Despite the fanfare over his various contributions, other than one polynomial curve, none of them were particularly new -- he just understood the correct way to publicise himself. As you will soon see, Descartes was indeed more of an influencer than either a mathematician or a philosopher. In his discussions with Fermat, he often misrepresented his work and stubbornly held onto his own inferior and sometimes incorrect assertions.

Despite his lack of scholarly skills, his work would soon leave its mark on the world -- creating nightmares beyond our imagination while inducing amnesia upon the Earth.

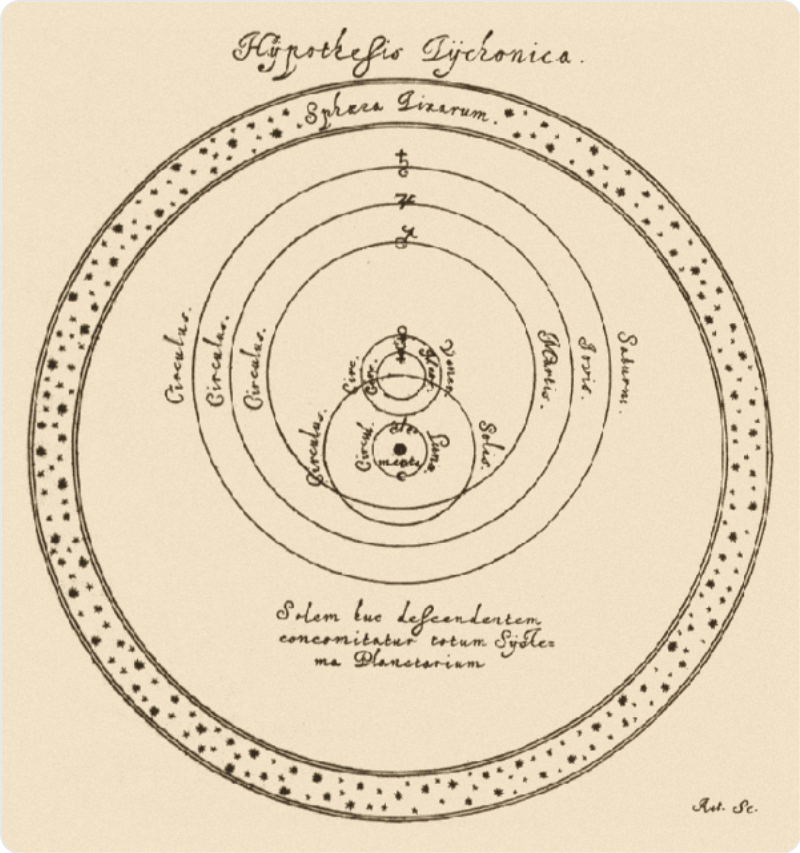
Next up, let's dive into his "philosophical" works, being careful not to make the mistake of engaging with his theatre and as you will soon discover, the dark ritual he imposed on his readers.

* Heraclides had Mercury and Venus orbit the Sun, the Sun orbit the Earth, and everything else including the Sun orbit the Earth with epicycles.


STARS
SATURN
JUPITER
MARS
SUN
VENUS
MERCURY
MOON
EARTH
epicycles
rotating spheres

net, in quo terram cum orbe lunari tanquam epicyclo contineri diximus. Quinto loco Venus nono mense reducitur. Sextum deniq; locum Mercurius tenet, octuaginta dierum spacio circumcurrens. In medio uero omnium residet Sol. Quis enim in hoc

pulcherimo templo lampadem hanc in alio uel meliori loco poneret, quàm unde totum simul possit illuminare? Siquidem non inepte quidam lucernam mundi, alij mentem, alij rectorem un-



Though Philosophy was popular during the Renaissance, it is not the most popular degree that people pursue today. In the US out of 2 million graduates per year, only 8,000 of them study philosophy and only half of these do it as an only major. That's only 0.4% of all graduating students! Despite this, philosophy degrees and focused courses are over-represented in the following roles:

- Senior Intelligence Analysts/Leaders (>4%)
- CEOs (2%)
- Lawyers, as a double major (9%)
- Clergy (8%)

Among names you may be familiar with who studied philosophy: Bill Clinton, Emmanuel Macron, Pierre Trudeau, Peter Thiel, Carl Icahn the "activist investor", John O. Brennan (CIA director), William J. Casey (CIA Director), Richard Moore (MI6 director). The Oxford PPE course, which has a core philosophy component, also produced numerous leaders such as David Cameron, Liz Truss, Rishi Sunak, Bob Hawke***, Malcolm Fraser and Tony Abbott to name a few.

In addition to these individuals, the institutionalisation of philosophy for interior government roles is very significant. Georgetown school of Foreign Service and other Jesuit institutions are practically a direct pipeline to the CIA and other intelligence or governmental organisations. All base their course work on philosophies borne out of one man: Rene Descartes.*

Yet, this is merely the direct influence of this man. His Meditation on First Philosophy book published in 1641, influenced the course of the Renaissance itself, almost all philosophical works after him, and later in the 20th century, the very root of physics. The flow-on effects from his philosophy touches almost every single aspect of modern life. From science, policy and even entertainment, the psychology of those who adopted it will naturally also affect your life as well.

Yet, except for these philosophy students, hardly anyone is familiar with the work that inspired these consequent developments. Even among these students, as they receive Descartes typically as a 4 week component of their first year course work, they typically do not gain much more than the absorption of today's interpretation of his work. They rarely look at the history of the man, the context in which he wrote his work, his true character and the ancient influences of his work. They mostly know him for Cartesian Geometry, without understanding what it is or what his true contribution to it was.

You probably know where I'm going with this: we are going to fix this severe deficiency in this thread, and become familiar with the man, his work, his true capabilities, what influenced him and the true state of his psychology. What will we gain? There is a two fold gain:
- By understanding the man who created the philosophy that major leaders adopt without question, we understand them at a deeper level than they possibly understand themselves.
- By understanding the man AND his philosophy, we can begin to unravel it, not merely to build upon it, but to completely strip it of its mystery. Then we are going to deconstruct using ancient epistemology and essentially invert it using modern ontological observations. Basically, we are going to tear it to bits.

Taken together, this makes the leaders of this world far more predictable to us: for example, their collective desire of transhumanism (especially Peter Thiel's) will soon become not only childish but also rather boring. It will also help us understand the two pronged attack on knowledge, observational methodologies and ultimately teleology, launched by the masters of the "enlightenment". I dare say, we will not be able to do this without knowing the man himself, so we shall begin with this.
Rene Descartes was born in 1596, in La Haye en Touraine, France. His father, Joachim Descartes, was an influencial member of parliament. Unfortunately for Rene, he was born to two tragedies. His mother passed soon after his birth, leaving him spiritually alone and without the irreplaceable love of a mother that defines the very being of a man. To make matters worse, he inherited her persistent cough and frail constitution, making him very prone to illnesses. Indeed, his doctors predicted he would never make it to adulthood. This left Descartes bed ridden, he would often sleep 10-12 hours a day, meaning his dreams or sleeping state constituted half of his life.

Descartes's father loved his son and called him "his philosopher" because of his inquisitive nature, so he arranged for his son to receive the best education in Europe at the Jesuit college of La Flèche. There he was given exceptional treatment, with private tutoring, and was allowed to attend courses at noon, rather than 5 AM as was expected of students around him. He would rarely associate with people or build friendships due to this. Over time this developed into a desire to remain hidden (almost anonymous), adopting the philosophy: Bene vixit, bene qui latuit, or "he lives well, he who remains concealed".

Descartes didn't stay in France for long though, traveling throughout Europe. In 1618, while studying to join the army of the prince of Orange in Netherlands as a mathematician, he met a man that would change his life forever: a Calvinist named Isaac Beeckman. This man had a deep disregard for Aristotelian philosophy and metaphysics, and advocated for a mechanical physics and atomism. In some regards, he was far ahead of his time and we would only discover this in the 20th century. Unfortunately, he is such an obscure figure in history that not even a photograph of him exists today.

The two men met near a large placard in Breda marketplace, both attracted by a detailed mathematical problem. They hit it off immediately and his influence on Descartes was dramatic. Descartes was a Catholic and was well versed in the philosophy of Aquinas that merged Christian theology and Aristotelian philosophy. Under Beeckman's influence, he came to see Aristotle's metaphysics, which was based on ancient ontology, as an impediment to thought itself.

In the mean time, Beeckman encouraged Descartes to solve and publish problems, resulting in his first book, Compendium Musicae, published in 1619. This kicked off his reputation as both a mathematician and philosopher. Descartes would add to this known detail, stating that a series of three dreams were seen by him as a revelation from God to go down this path...

Unfortunately for Descartes, in 1624, the French parliament would make contradicting Aristotle punishable by death. This was a complete desecration of Aristotle's spirit, as he believed in philosophical debate and criticism, rational argument over authority, and the combined power of epistemology and ontology through dialectic discourse. Without a counterparty that is free to speak, there is no discourse and no need for Aristotle's ingenious language formalism. Descartes, feeling intellectually suffocated, decided to leave France for good in 1628, and headed to the Netherlands.
There he began working on the mathematical physics theory that Beeckman pushed him into. He would particularly focus on problems in optics -- as it were, his mentor Beeckman was from the same Middleburg town that specialised in this field, and this would have surely influenced Descartes.

During this period of history, geometry was solved using geometric methods -- Euclidian in nature and sometimes cumbersome without lifelong dedication to the field. Algebra, on the other hand, was used to solve complicated relationships symbolically. Combining these two would be a boon: optimistically, there would be no need to imagine curves -- solutions would drop out of equations. Descartes would develop this for years, resulting in his second most significant book: a combined Philosophy-math-physics book Discourse on the Method, published in 1637. Here his analytical geometry, and optics solutions, would exist as appendices.

For Descartes, these were merely demonstrations of the power of his methods: A complete dismantlement of Aristotle's philosophy, and the scholastic method. There was trouble for Descartes though, as Fermat had priority, releasing Methodus ad Disquirendam Maximam et Minimam et de Tangentibus Linearum Curvarum in 1636, with a superior methodology for combining algebra with geometry. In fact, what we now know as Cartesian geometry, more

closely resembles Fermat's method than Descartes'.

To rub salt on the wound, Fermat had already developed this in 1629 as he could prove by correspondences, he just had not published it. Curiously, this well known piece of history is left out of most biographies of Descartes that read by academic students. This is likely because he has to be seen to demonstrate some novel application of his methods.

In any case, Descartes was furious! Fermat, to him, was a mere lawyer. Math was just a hobby, and yet he was an absolute giant compared to Descartes. Here he was taking away the most significant development of his life. He sent Fermat a challenge so that the two could put their geometrical methods to the test: the folium of Descartes. Descartes suggested that Fermat try and find the tangent line of $x^3 + y^3 = 3axy$ at any point of the curve.

Embarrassingly, not only did Fermat do this with ease using his method, Descartes had two compounded failures: He failed to solve his own problem, and he could not properly imagine the full quadrant leaf-like shape of the curve whereas Fermat could. This was an absolute scandal, the 'father of analytical geometry', could not properly draw the curve to his own equation. Descartes would send letters defaming Fermat behind his back, and the arguments that arose from it were quite heated. This wasn't abnormal for Descartes!

Many years earlier, had burnt bridges with Beeckman, all over a similar need to own an idea. Beeckman was proud of Descartes, claiming him to be his old student and Descartes interpreted this as an attempt to steal his work. In fact, he hurt him so badly that the two never recovered in their friendship. Increasingly isolated, and without a true significant result to his name, Descartes communicated that he began to worry about his place in history. His Method book, on the backdrop of these events, would not get much attention -- not yet anyway.

A few years earlier, he had an illegitimate child with his personal maid, who he named Francine Descartes. Heartbreakingly, she inherited his frail composition, and died of scarlet fever at the age of 5. Descartes deeply loved his daughter, and upon her death was filled with so much sorrow that he couldn't stop crying. It was said that he would hold a coffin-like box while he slept every night, with other rumours (likely untrue) that he built an android like mechanical replacement of it. One thing is certain: This was the worst moment of Descartes life and it would scar him as a father in ways that would never ever heal.

The same man who lived in virtual anonymity and held back Le Monde after seeing what had happened to Galileo, suddenly had a different direction. In the darkest hour of his soul, he releases a different kind of book, one that would change the course of history and perhaps one that could very well be the cause of our extinction should we not properly study it: Meditations, 1641. This book was a perversion of philosophies of the time, wrapped around a dark ritual and many old ideas.

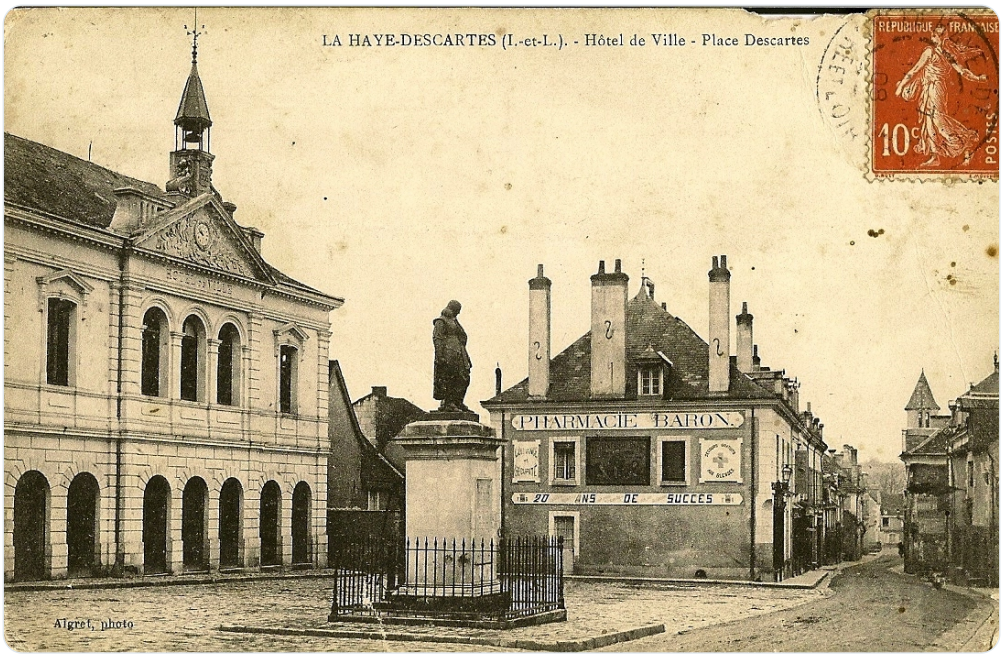
We will discuss this book, and his methods, in great detail in the next section. For now, it's important to note that Meditations caused Descartes to be declared an atheist by many Calvinists in protestant dominated Netherlands. He was condemned by the university of the town he was staying at, Utrecht, leading him to flee to the Hague. He remained in the Netherlands until 1649 under the protection of its prince.

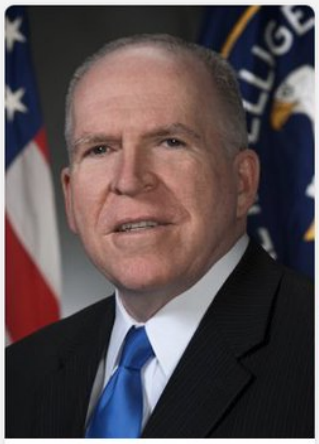
He left the country in 1650, heading to Sweden to teach Queen Christina. She did not like him very much, and forced him to get up at 5 AM in order to teach her. His frail body could not handle this, and his illnesses finally catch up with him, causing him to die of pneumonia**.

Before continuing, let us pray for his soul and for God to forgive him for his mistakes. Descartes was a truly tragic, isolated figure, not dissimilar to your oomfie in many of his qualities, methods and isolation.

May, you rest in peace, Rene Descartes. 🌹🙏🏻

* I wanted to make sure of this for myself, so I searched the course work of the top 40 universities in the world, and also sampled the top 200 universities. The inclusion of Rene Descartes in their courses is universal. You cannot study philosophy today without touching his work and being influenced by it.
** I am aware of the theory that he was killed by a Catholic Priest Jacques Viogué, who slipped arsenic into his communion wafer. I have not done sufficient research to determine the veracity of this claim, and in a sense, I hope it isn't true because it would make this already tragic story that much more tragic.
*** Back then it was called Modern Greats.





John O. Brennan

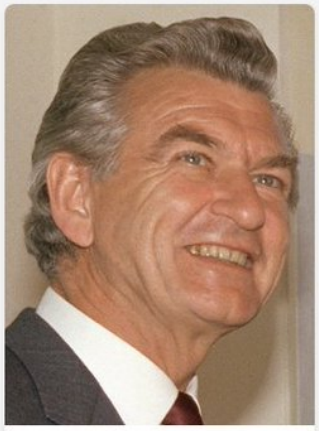
William J. Casey

Richard Moore

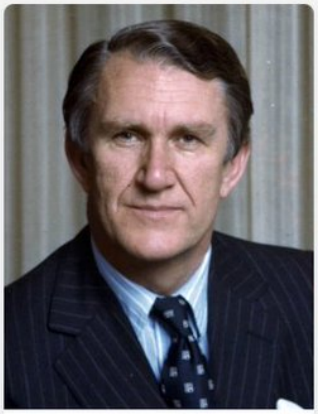
David Cameron

Liz Truss

Peter Thiel



Bob Hawke



Malcolm Fraser

Bill Clinton

Now that we are familiar with the philosopher and the historical context he lived in, we are now equipped to enter the ground zero of modern philosophy, Rene Descartes' Meditations on First Philosophy: In Which The Existence of God and the Distinction of the Human Soul from the Body are Demonstrated (1641).

The title is quite interesting. Meditation is a spiritual technique, popular at the time among both Christian and occult practitioners in Europe, and this is the primary purpose of the book as Descartes mentions in his forward to the reader. In fact, Rene claimed one would get no value from it unless they meditated along with him while reading it:

"I seek to be read by none, except those who will be able and willing to meditate seriously alongside me, and to withdraw their minds from the senses, and at the same time from all their preconceptions."

Rene titled his book a First Philosophy in order to claim to be a foundational philosophy. Back then it would have likely seemed bold. In retrospect, it was quite an accurate choice! The majority of today's philosophy is at least founded on one or more propositions encoded in the book. The book revolves around the two other things mentioned in the title, a "proof of God" and a distinctive split of body and soul, otherwise known as dualism.

Unstated in the title is the pursuit of certainty. Descartes' claim is that substantial certainty can only be achieved through its privation: systematic doubt. This is the source of "radical skepticism" that has plagued almost all discourse today. Descartes mission was clearly stated in his correspondence and prior material: to destroy scholasticism. He actually destroyed far more than that as we shall see.

Meditations is a Frankenstein of a book, mixing primitive theology, flaky philosophy, botched mathematical conceptualisation, and crude physics. This is then packaged up as a psychological attack on the reader. This isn't mere speculation, but if you read on, you will see that Rene admits it himself to his confidants in letters we now have access to.

Disturbingly, the book is modelled after some Christian mystical rituals (Ignatius's Spiritual Exercises, Dark Night of the Soul by St. John of the Cross) and some elements of occult texts. It is organised in a peculiar form, each chapter is referred to as a "day". This seemingly follows the structure of Spiritual Exercises, but with far fewer days, mirroring the six days of creation in Genesis.

I will now go through a book outline as I suspect the majority of my readers have not, and should not, read Meditations. As mentioned I will prove beyond doubt that this book is a psychological attack, so reading it in third person with me will keep your psyche safe.

Book Outline

The book begins with a letter to the dean of Sorbonne in France, justifying its publications and with some forced piety. The significance of this section will be discussed later. Following it is a preface to the reader which we mentioned earlier, followed by a helpful synopsis.

In the letter to the dean, Descartes outlines that he is writing this book for unbelievers who

see a circular argument in the need to believe in God: God is justified by the scripture, which in turn justifies God. He invites them to endorse his work. It's notable that the department never replied to this letter.

In Meditation I, Descartes points out that some of the opinions he's held in the past proved to be wrong, and his senses have fooled him. So now he's going to doubt everything he's been taught and start from scratch. He doesn't stop there though, describing himself sitting by a fire, wrapped in a comfy gown, handling paper with a pen using his hands, he wonders if he is dreaming and these "extensions" of his do not exist at all.

He then begins to doubt ideas involving "composite things", claiming that only the simplest things may be true in his dream. After some pearl clutching, he even doubts the existence of God -- claiming to desire to prove this existence instead. This is actually the most significant and dangerous part of the book as you'll see later. For now, let us flag the reality that an active reader is now also at least entertaining this doubt.

He then sinks into the dreaming state and conjures an "evil genius" (or spirit in some translations), who is "cunning" and has "devoted all his effort" into deceiving the reader. This genius has made the reader think that all the sky, air, Earth, colors and so on, are no different to the illusions from the aforementioned dream. A modern approach to this kind of thing is to imagine yourself as a "brain in a jar" with all external senses being simulated.

This first important "day" is concluded with complete darkness, no belief in God, and the possibility that he is merely an illusion conjured by an evil genius.

The next "day" arrives in Meditation II; Descartes and the reader have now completely zeroed out their priors and do not believe in anything at all. To quote him indirectly, he believes that none of his memory is true, and that he doesn't even have a body or even a presence in space. He needs something to continue on, otherwise, with his priors being all false or at least "uncertain" (doubted), no proposition can be certain or true. For a moment, he lingers on to think of God, but quickly dismisses that possibility, thinking that "God, or whatever he should be called", may be a figment of his imagination. That's when he drops into his famous meme, the Cogito:

He realises that if he's doubting, he must be thinking! Hence, if he's thinking, he must exist. Cogito, ergo sum! I would like to imagine that philosophers all over Europe spilled their soy lattes reading that line, which is ironic because, technically the argument he produced is actually: Dubito, ergo cogito, ergo sum. Not as catchy and more importantly, wasn't new. You see, Augustine made the exact same argument in his book City of God published in 426 AD: Si fallor, sum. I shall prove that Descartes deliberately obscured this prior reference for good reason, he needed the Cogito to continue his project.

He then defines himself as a thinking thing (res cogitans), and his body as an extension (res extensa). Introducing a soul-body dualism, justifying it by this radical doubt of having no body, only thoughts so far. The reader is of course induced into this as well, and previous arguments, assumptions are tortured into them through repetition with emphasis that they must still be asleep.

This type of dualism is actually a re-emphasis of an Augustine/Neo-Platonic perspective that contradicts the more holistic and yet subtle argument raised by Aquinas and his scholasticism, which we will discuss in the next part of the thread.

Most revealing, however, in this chapter is his inversion of the Aristotelian wax example. Aristotle mentions wax specifically as a substance that can be heated, and then shaped into a form. This is a very important idea which Descartes throws out, in favour of a reduction of the wax into the senses induced by it during it solidified state (it's smell, rigidity and so on) compared to its flowing state. In here, he attacks the ontological principle of holism present in Aristotle, and pushes his reductionism as being more consistent. Descartes injects a perspective: the wax is only wax because he perceives it as such even during its state transition.

The next day arrives in Meditation III and his increasingly weary reader is finally allowed to have a 'God' back. But it's not the same God as they may have started with! No, this 'God' is a philosophical one, one that he arrives at by a recollection of a mere memory or a clear and distinct perception of a perfect being he calls 'God'. Its perceived perfection justifies its existence at this point.

This chapter is the most disturbing of all, and it's not because of the content but because of the greatest density of the usage of the first perspective, as well as the greatest density of the usage of the word 'God' alongside it. It's not merely a textual, conceptual but also a visual union with this 'God'.

Later in this chapter, Descartes then doubts this existence again, and offers a subsistence proof, claiming that because he's imperfect and this 'God' is perfect, this 'God' must thus be sustaining him. This is another copy of Augustine's prior argument in confessions book I and XI. This particular argument relies on a cosmology called ex nihilo which we will discuss later.

The increasingly weary reader moves on to Meditation IV, where discernment is discussed. Here I will only note an attack on Aristotle's categories, and substance teleology, claiming that:

"I judge that the whole category of causes that people are in the habit of seeking by considering the purpose of things is of no use in the study of physics, for I think that it could only be rash of me to investigate God's purposes."

This naturally extends to the entire universe and in a book he publishes in 1644 he states this explicitly. Essentially, this chapter discards teleology all together. To Descartes the universe has no purpose. The rest of the chapter is a flaky argument about why a perfect 'God' would have us err, I will not get into it, as it will serve little purpose to us beyond noting he made this point.

The tortured reader makes it to the second last day, Meditation V, where the other meme, the "Cartesian circle" is stated. Here, Descartes makes the following argument:

Whatever we perceive clearly and distinctly is guaranteed to be true by God.

He doesn't define clear and distinct here, but in short it's anything that can be separated out and "perceived by an attentive mind". Essentially, it's a reductionist perspective, where only the simplest things are guaranteed to behave in a way we can perceive correctly.

But wait, his clear and distinct mere perception (memory/idea) of God guaranteed God's existence, which in turn guarantees his clear and distinct perception. This essentially undermines the entire purpose he claimed this book held in the letter he sent to the dean at the start.

Finally, the exhausted, anxious and confused reader reaches Meditation VI, where Descartes rebuilds his body, giving it a stamp of approval. He renounces the radical doubt that built it up, claiming that it was ridiculous after all and the dream is over. As a parting gift to the reader, Descartes explains his hierarchy of intellect: intuition at the top, imagination in the middle and the senses that they just got back at the very bottom.

Finally, he takes the reader out of the brain in the jar and creates a union of the mind and body, with a twist. To Descartes, the body has a physical extent, but the mind does not -- it is on a different plane! It has no shape and it isn't even point-like. It is indivisible, thus not substantial in the same way as a body. This is a critical point that we will be revisiting in great detail so keep it in mind.

The book closes on some objections and answers, which I will not get into, but the reader can finally rest now, back at their home.

Their faith in God is restored!
They are confident in their existence as a mind and body.
They are ready to apply Descartes reductionist methodology and methodical doubt to discover the world!
Everything is as it should be...

Or is it? Is it still the same person? Certainly not, every active reading of a book changes the reader. Do they hold the same beliefs?

No, because the 'God' they now believe in is not God at all, they are now dysmorphic with their conceptualisation of their body and, tragically, have no purpose in this universe other than to persist.

To Descartes though, his mission was complete! He delivered a coup de grace against the Aquinasian scholasticism that prevented his publication of Le Monde in 1633 and imprisoned Galileo.

Why did Descartes need to destroy scholasticism?
Why did Aquinas create scholasticism at all?
How did this hurt Christianity as a whole and plunge us into a spiritual dark age?
What was Descartes' true motivation and affiliation?

Find out in the next part!

RENATI

DES-CARTES,

MEDITATIONES DE PRIMA PHILOSOPHIA,

IN QVA DEI EXISTENTIA ET ANIMÆ IMMORTALITAS DEMONSTRATVR.

PARISIIS,
Apud MICHAELEM SOLY, viâ Iacobeâ, sub signo Phœnicis.

M. DC. XLI.

Cum Priuilegio, & Approbatione Doctorum.

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DISCARD

IMAGINARY

I perceived clearly, although in fact I was not really perceiving it; namely, that there were certain things existing outside me from which these ideas derived and that the ideas perfectly resembled. This was my mistake; or at least, if I was after all right in thinking this, the rightness was not due to my perception.

36 But when in arithmetic or geometry I considered something very simple and easy—for instance, two plus three equals five—surely I intuited this kind of thing at least clearly enough to declare it true? In fact, when I later judged that such things should be doubted, this was only because the thought had come to me, that perhaps some God might have endowed me with such a nature that I could be deceived even about those things that appeared supremely obvious. But whenever this preconceived opinion of God's supreme power occurs to me, I cannot help admitting, that, if indeed he wishes to, he can easily bring it about that I should be mistaken, even about matters that I think I intuit with the eye of the mind as evidently as possible. On the other hand, whenever I turn my attention to the things themselves that I think I perceive very clearly, I am so thoroughly convinced by them, that I cannot help exclaiming: 'Let whoever can, deceive me as much as he likes: still he can never bring it about that I am nothing, as long as I think I am something; or that one day it will be true that I have never existed, when it is true now that I exist; or that perhaps two plus three added together are more or less than five; or that other such things should be true in which I recognize an obvious contradiction.' And certainly, since I have no grounds for thinking that any deceitful God exists—in fact, I do not yet sufficiently know whether there is any God at all—then a reason for doubting that depends wholly on the belief in a deceitful God is very slight, and, so to speak, metaphysical. In order to remove it, then, at the first opportunity, I must examine whether there is a God, and, if there is, whether he can be a deceiver; since, as long as I remain ignorant of this matter, I seem unable ever to be certain of any other at all.*

But now it seems that, to proceed in an orderly fashion, I should
37 first divide up all my thoughts into definite categories, and examine to which of these truth and falsity can properly be said to pertain. Some of these thoughts are apparently images of things,* and to these alone the name 'idea' is properly applied: for instance, when I think of a human being, or a chimera, or the heavens, or an angel,

Literal Blasphemy

Parafoveal Processing, Rapid Visual Processing

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